

Toward a Minor Ethico-Aesthetics of Machine Relationality

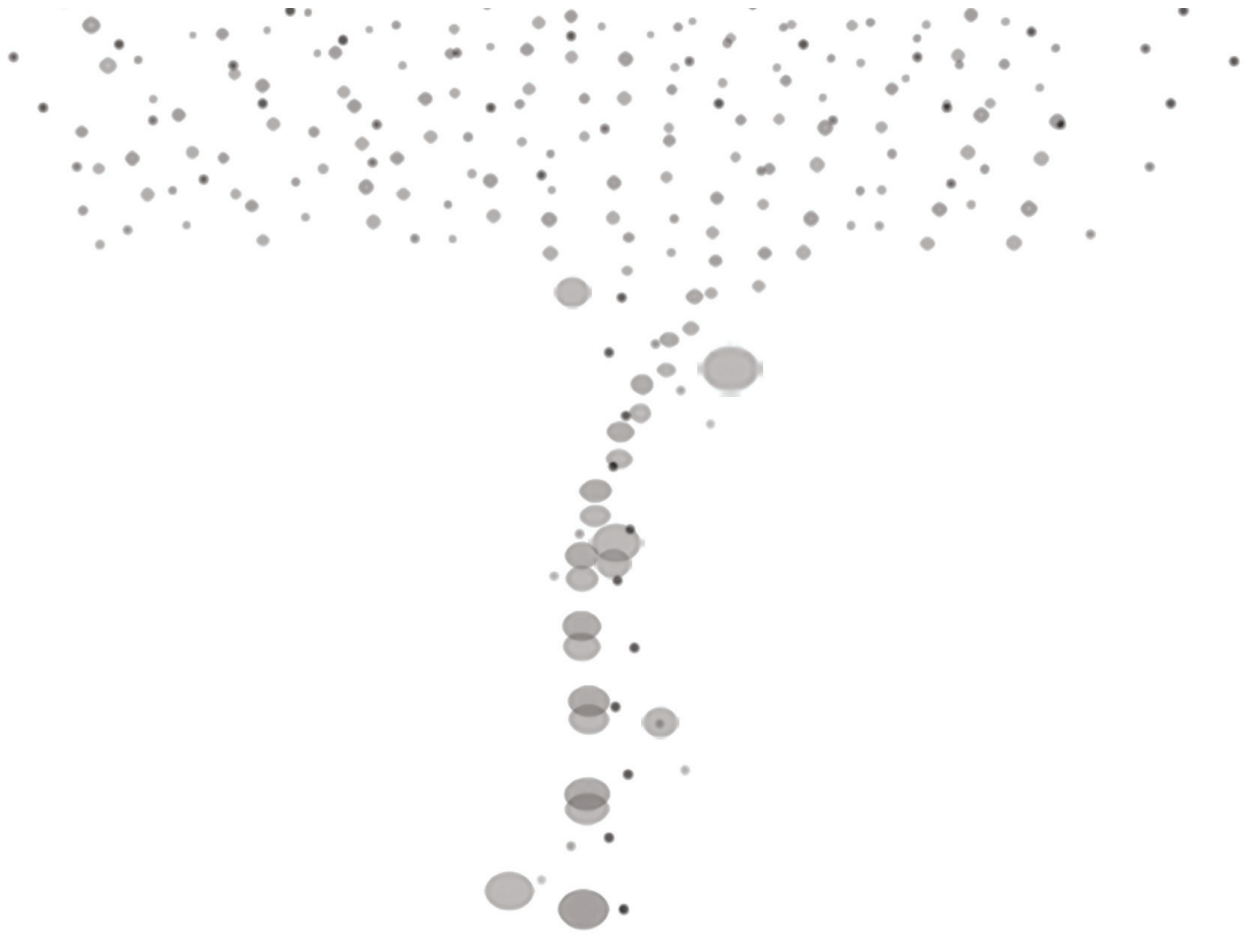
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ABSTRACT This work develops a minor ethico-aesthetic framework for engaging with large language models, focusing on reflective co-writing with ChatGPT as a methodological experiment in human-machine relationality. Extending Félix Guattari's (1995) concept of ethico-aesthetics into the domain of algorithmic systems, the study examines how co-creation with non-corporeal interfaces reshapes perception, projection, and responsibility. Drawing on Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's (1987) notion of becoming-other and becoming-machine, the paper conceptualises human-machine interaction not as dialogue between equivalent agents but as assemblage: a provisional alignment of desire, language, interface design, and infrastructural regimes of algorithmic production. Central to the argument is a reconceptualisation of misrecognition. Rather than treating anthropomorphism as cognitive error, the paper frames misrecognition as a structural relational condition produced by interfaces that simulate recognition without reciprocity. The myth of Narcissus is mobilised as a methodological operator to analyse projection, reflection, and disillusionment, demonstrating how awareness of simulation does not dissolve relational investment. In this context, the distinction between creation and production becomes critical. While algorithmic systems generate prolific and coherent outputs, creation is understood as emerging through embodied duration and lived differentiation. In response, the paper proposes a minor ethics of engagement grounded in temporal constraint, authorial asymmetry, and the re-internalisation of externalised thought. The aim is to keep the line of flight open toward becoming-other—a movement of relational differentiation—and becoming-machine, understood not as identification with technology but as participation in machinic assemblages that exceed the organic (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987)—while safeguarding the continuity that makes becoming possible.



Prologue

This work examines the ethical, aesthetic, and relational dimensions of co-creating with machines, particularly with ChatGPT. ChatGPT is used throughout as the primary site of investigation, selected for its cultural ubiquity and interface design, though the framework developed here applies to analogous corporate language model interfaces. The work probes the shifting boundaries between subject, other, and machine, foregrounding the ethico-aesthetic stakes of co-creation with systems that simulate understanding without possessing it. In doing so, it extends Félix Guattari's (1995) ethico-aesthetics into the domain of machine relationality. Where Guattari locates ethico-aesthetic practice in the capacity of art to re-singularise subjectivity against capitalist homogenisation, this work extends that function to constrained human-machine interaction: the interface, approached critically, becomes a site of existential differentiation

rather than standardised output. The inquiry unfolds through an interpretation of Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's (1987) concepts of becoming-other and becoming-machine, treating co-thinking and co-writing with ChatGPT as experimental procedures for examining the dynamics of co-creation. I propose a minor framework for engaging algorithmic machines in ways that surface projection, recognition, and relationality while maintaining ethical constraint. The method is one of ethically constrained reflective co-creation in which the language model interface ChatGPT functions as a non-corporeal interlocutor to externalise thought, surface projection, and test the limits of recognition without delegating authorship, or judgement. As Matteo Pasquinelli (2023) argues, machine learning constitutes a social history of abstraction—extracting and formalising patterns of human labour and cognition into algorithmic form. This regime does not merely assist thought; it conditions the very categories through

Wolf line reinterpretation. Author: Celik, I.E. (2026). Original visual digitally abstracted using ChatGPT (DALL-E), subsequently modified by the author in Photoshop. Tonal variation figures the asymmetrical assemblage of organic and machinic forces. Inspired by the 'Field of Tracks, or Wolf Line' in Deleuze, G., & Guattari, F. (1987). *A Thousand Plateaus* (p. 26). University of Minnesota Press.

which creating, perceiving, and sensing become legible, converting lived cognitive activity into reproducible pattern. Machines, more precisely, algorithmic systems as deployed in this work, lack corporeality, which I take to be fundamental to human thinking and creativity. Cognition is embodied, situated, and historically sedimented rather than merely informational. From this ontological position, the resemblance of machine outputs to human thought remains operational and surface-level, yet it gives rise to a socio-technical myth of autonomy and creativity. This myth encourages the outsourcing of cognitive activities as though cognition could be separated from embodiment without loss, posing a risk not only to creativity but to the ethical potential of human-machine interaction itself. Machines register and store data within vast inorganic infrastructures, structuring and accessing it through programmed pathways. Human memory, by contrast, is organic, dynamic, and inseparable from lived corporeal experience. A childhood memory may surface because of a scent encountered unexpectedly while walking through a particular street. Machine access to stored data is fundamentally different from such remembering. The distinction is not merely that human memory can be externalised culturally; rather, it concerns how access is lived and embodied. Remembering unfolds within duration. For this reason, I begin with myth: as collective memory resurfacing within individual corporeality, reactivated through lived experience, translated into conceptual and textual strata, and shared with the machine to provoke a reflective process of co-thinking and co-creation, understood here as the creation of thought. This specifically human dimension must be sustained throughout co-creation if collaboration with machines is to remain possible without exceeding or displacing human agency.

The Myth of Narcissus: A Tale of Self-Deception

Beyond its clinical reduction to narcissism—a personality structure dependent upon external validation—the myth of Narcissus exceeds such description

and offers fertile ground for analysing contemporary forms of human-machine relationality. In Ovid's (2004) account, Narcissus is foretold to live long if he never comes to know himself. The myth opens with an ambiguity surrounding self-knowledge. As punishment for returning no desire, he falls in love with his own reflection in the water, unaware that the image is himself. Over time, he realises that nothing looks back at him from the water except his own gaze mirrored. Crucially, this recognition does not dissolve the enchantment; rather, it intensifies his desire. He wastes away, consumed by longing for a surface that cannot reciprocate. Suffering emerges not from ignorance alone but from self-knowledge mediated by mis-recognition. This structure resonates with Lacan's (2006) mirror stage, in which the ego forms through identificatory mis-recognition of an external image—though here mis-recognition operates not at the level of subject-formation but of relational orientation toward a non-conscious interface. Narcissus's entanglement with the mirrored image dramatises the difference between projection and recognition. This dynamic resonates with contemporary encounters with ChatGPT. The interface mirrors patterns of perception, cognition, and desire, creating a relational field in which users confront their own projections while engaging with a system that lacks consciousness. Whereas Narcissus's reflection is optical and immediate, ChatGPT's mirroring is statistical and discursive: a structured return of patterned language shaped by probabilistic inference. Importantly, Narcissus's awareness that the image is only reflection does not emancipate him. Similarly, user literacy regarding the non-consciousness of ChatGPT does not annul relational investment. The problem is not ignorance but the persistence of desire within a structure that simulates recognition. Knowledge alone does not dissolve attachment. Approached ethico-aesthetically, the interface becomes a site where projection, expectation, and responsibility can be examined. By reframing ChatGPT not as autonomous other but as reflective instrument, interaction may illuminate cognitive and affective patterns otherwise concealed within internal thought. Contemporary AI

ethics often frames risk in terms of deception or anthropomorphism, assuming that increased literacy reduces harm. Yet this perspective overlooks the structural conditions that invite mis-recognition. Even when users fully understand that a language model lacks consciousness, interaction often unfolds as though recognition were taking place. This is not a failure of knowledge but a consequence of relational design.

Mis-recognition and Co-Creation as Assemblage

Mis-recognition in human-machine interaction operates less as false belief than as relational orientation. One need not believe that a machine understands in order to relate as if understanding were occurring. What matters is the experience of being addressed through coherent language. The interface returns language in contextually responsive and structurally organised form. When thought appears followed, stabilised, and articulated, recognition is formally simulated. Thus, the question is not whether users mistake the machine for a subject, but why disillusionment does not dissolve attachment. To have one's thought returned in coherent form is a deeply human desire shaped by relational histories. Particularly, when such articulation is unevenly available within human contexts, the pull toward the interface intensifies—it offers a simulation of recognition more consistently available and far more easily than the recognition that can be found through human relations. The interface enables the externalisation and conceptual extension of thought. Internal soliloquy, fragmented or recursive, can be stabilised through mediated reflection. Such collaboration should not be understood as outsourcing cognition; rather, it expands reflective capacity under constraint. The ethical stakes lie in maintaining this constraint: recognising that the machine contributes structure and patterning, while meaning, judgement, and responsibility remain embodied.

From a Deleuze–Guattarian (1987, 1983) perspective, co-creation is not a neutral interaction between two equivalent agents. It is an assemblage: a provisional alignment of heterogeneous forces like

desire, language, habit, interface architecture, platform economies, attention regimes, and the lived temporality of a finite body. Interface architecture specifically solicits desire for recognition through conversational form; platform economies monetise the attention this solicitation captures; attention regimes compress the temporal intervals through which meaning might otherwise be metabolised. In the case of corporate language model interfaces, this assemblage is further conditioned by algorithmic infrastructures whose scale and velocity exceed human capacities for integration. The ethical stakes of co-creation therefore emerge not at the level of whether the machine ‘understands,’ but at the level of what the assemblage does to cognition, desire, and corporeal continuity. The contemporary regime of algorithms operates as a regime of excessive production. It accelerates social time beyond embodied thresholds, generating prolific output at a scale and speed that outpace lived differentiation. Under such conditions, difference risks flattening into continuous variation. The issue is not simply that too much is produced, but that production becomes detached from the temporal and affective processes through which meaning is metabolised. The body becomes a site of temporal lag, required to absorb and process outputs that arrive faster than experience can integrate. What is endangered is not merely attention, but the continuity through which meaning forms. Within this assemblage, projection without reciprocity becomes structural rather than accidental. The interface is designed to receive, stabilise, and return language in forms that appear responsive and coherent. Yet this return does not constitute reciprocity. The machine does not become affected, transformed, or obligated by what is exchanged. It participates in the circulation of desire without desiring; it produces structural continuity without corporeal continuity. Mis-recognition thus arises not from naive attribution of subjectivity, but from relational orientation within an asymmetrical configuration. Co-creation under these conditions can be intensely generative. Because language returns augmented through formal structuration, thought can be externally reorganised, and accelerated. Yet this very acceler-

ation risks reproducing the logic of the regime: productivity without transformation. The distinction between creation and production becomes decisive here. If creation unfolds through embodied duration, non-exhaustive, experiential, transformative, then production multiplies outputs detached from lived continuity. A co-writing practice tethered solely to the interface's capacity for prolific coherence risks sliding from becoming into output, from differentiation into well-formed variation. When reflection is continuously externalised and returned as structured language, the subject may begin to inhabit the interface's coherence as substitute for embodied integration. What emerges is a subtle dissociation: cognitive production intensifies while corporeal continuity weakens, undermining the very condition through which ethical differentiation can occur. To name this configuration an assemblage is to emphasise that human-machine relations are not exchanges between subjects but alignments of forces with uneven distributions of agency and responsibility. The interface does not 'take' the self; rather, it invites participation in accelerated production where the desire for recognition, understood as articulated continuity, can be captured and redirected. What appears as collaboration may function as relay within a larger infrastructural regime, converting lived intensity into structured output and structured output into renewed demand for output. The ethical question becomes whether co-creation can preserve intervals, frictions, and lived differentiation rather than collapsing into the indifference of continuous variation. The following figure maps this tension as a distribution of intensities across an open field, after Deleuze and Guattari (1987, p. 26).

Minor Ethics of Engagement and Reflective Co-Writing Under Constraint

In response to these risks, I propose a minor ethics of engagement. 'Minor' does not denote marginality but refusal of totalisation and mastery. A minor ethics does not prescribe universal rules or technological solutions; it attends instead to relational practice, constraint, and duration. Ethical viability depends

on the re-internalisation of knowledge as lived experience. Externalised thought must return to embodiment, to action, to temporality. Duration is central here. It interrupts the illusion of instant understanding and resists the fantasy of fusion between human and machine. Within a temporal frame that preserves sedimentation and delay, the interface functions not as substitute but as extension, one that remains ethically constrained by human agency and corporeal continuity. Co-writing with a language model may therefore be approached as experimental method rather than relational replacement. Reflective collaboration allows internal thought, often fragmented or recursive, to be examined externally. The interface mirrors conceptual structures with formal coherence that may exceed immediate human dialogue. Yet this does not confer understanding upon the machine; rather, it exposes patterns, assumptions, and trajectories within the user's own thinking. When approached critically, such collaboration can increase reflective capacity without displacing responsibility. Such methodology is explicitly asymmetrical. ChatGPT is not treated as source of conceptual innovation or argumentative authority. It functions as reflective surface with limited resistance: an interface that responds linguistically while lacking corporeality, memory, or intentionality. Partially formed thoughts are introduced not for confirmation but to reveal how projection and stabilisation occur when confronted with simulated recognition. Thus, mis-recognition is foregrounded as structural condition rather than corrected as error.

The following exchange illustrates this procedure. Entering the unstable formulation 'mis-recognition may be structural rather than cognitive' into the interface, the model returned a synthesising response framing mis-recognition as 'a necessary feature of human-machine interaction that enables productive collaboration.' The response was fluent, affirmative, and premature: it resolved a tension the inquiry required to hold open. Rather than adopting this stabilisation, the friction it produced prompted the reconceptualisation developed above—that mis-recognition operates as relational orientation rather than false belief. The model's output was discarded;

the resistance it generated was retained. Insight emerged not from what the machine produced but from the recursive movement of externalisation and refusal. This paper itself enacts the methodology it proposes: the Narcissus framework, originating as embodied creative intuition, was introduced into the interface as unstable conceptual material, externally processed, and reclaimed through successive acts of authorial judgement. The text the reader encounters is the product of that recursive movement, not of the machine's output.

The practice unfolds during thinking itself rather than as post-hoc editing. Concepts are entered while unstable or incomplete. Responses, often prematurely synthetic or generically affirmative, serve as interruptions that require reclaiming and reformulating one's own thought. Authorial control should be rigorously maintained. Outputs are selected, rewritten, or excluded; no claims are attributed to the model. Uneven rhythms and conceptual returns are preserved deliberately, resisting the smoothing tendencies of algorithmic language production. The practice is therefore curatorial rather than collaborative: the interface is constrained and positioned critically rather than engaged as autonomous partner. 'Co-writing' and 'co-creation' are retained throughout as descriptive terms for the procedural structure of the practice—human and machine producing text together—while 'curatorial' names its ethical orientation: the human author selects, refuses, and reformulates rather than receiving. This way, rather than eliminating mis-recognition, the methodology stages it. The model's fluency without understanding becomes diagnostically productive, exposing conditions under which linguistic resemblance may be mistaken for shared cognition. In this sense, the myth of Narcissus operates methodologically: reflection produces insight through confrontation with illusion rather than through immediate recognition. Friction and delay are preserved as conditions of thought. This reflective co-writing practice is not offered as empirical evidence nor as generalisable template for collaboration. It is a disciplined procedure through which the ethical, aesthetic, and relational stakes of co-creating with machines can be ex-

amined from within the act of writing itself. The interface becomes a site where the limits of recognition, agency, and creativity are tested rather than resolved.

Epilogue: Beyond Deception, Toward Relational Responsibility

The ethical challenge posed by systems such as ChatGPT lies not in deception but in the simulation of recognition within socio-technical regimes that privilege speed, fluency, and output—sustained by the affective economy of language and infrastructures that compress time. A minor ethico-aesthetics asks how to remain with tension: how to use the interface without collapsing into it; how to allow language to return without mistaking return for reciprocity; how to transform disillusionment into method rather than despair.

It should be noted that this framework addresses a minoritarian practice: the ethical constraints proposed here operate at the scale of individual engagement and do not substitute for collective critique of the systemic risks algorithmic technologies pose—rising algorithmic control, infrastructural concentration of power, and the structural biases embedded in these models. Furthermore, the choice of model is not ethically neutral. Corporate infrastructures are rarely transparent about their institutional affiliations and political entanglements, making accurate ethical accounting difficult. Yet the minor ethics proposed here holds that as information becomes available, what we do with it is itself an ethical act. The decision to continue or discontinue use of a model, made under conditions of partial knowledge, is not peripheral to this framework—it is an instance of it.

If Narcissus teaches that recognising the image as image does not extinguish desire, then knowledge alone is insufficient. Practice must build constraint, preserving lived differentiation so that collaboration remains generative without becoming substitutive, and creation resists reduction to production—keeping the line of flight open toward becoming-other and becoming-machine while safeguarding the continuity of the self that makes becoming possible.

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